

One Wii Step At A Time

You don't have to go through it, but *Wii Sports* gives you a *Wii Fitness Test*, built to "test your skill and stamina." It takes you through a series of mini-games—based on *Wii Sports*' main games, that is—that will put you through your paces. You'll be asked to return as many balls as possible in *Tennis*, score some mildly challenging putts in *Golf*, get as many strikes as you can in *Bowling*, and so on. At the end, your scores are tallied and your *Wii Fitness Age* is calculated. The idea is to be as young as possible (at the very least, get your own chronological age), and you should take this test once a week to see how much progress you've made. This writer started out at a shameful 54, but after four hours of *Wii-ing*, came down to a less embarrassing 35. Clearly more *Wii* time is warranted.

On The Fields

Tennis is easily the most entertaining game of the lot—while the rest are simple to pick up and play, it's here that you'll find yourself wanting to improve continuously. The game is all about timing and power, and it's by balancing the two that you control the direction and speed of your shot—miss your timing, and you'll be hitting the ball right out of the court. Controlling your shot with the *Wiimote* is much like you would do in real life, and feels as natural as being there on the grass.

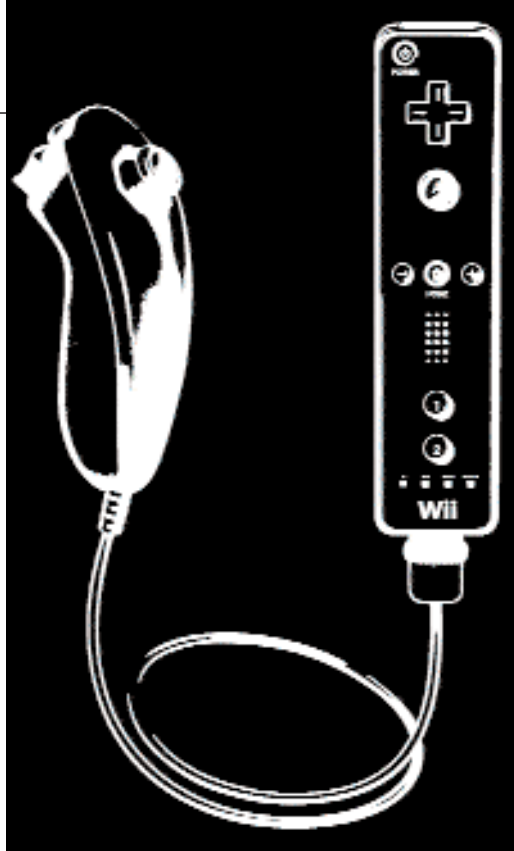
With some more practice, you can also get some spins in, though all we were able to accomplish were little more than flukes. You can also tell quite easily that this is going to be an excellent game if more people join in.

After *Tennis*, it's *Bowling* that's quite captivating—you can either use the simple hold-down-B-and-twitch method to get your strikes, or practise more elaborate moves like spinning the ball to nail difficult shots. Here, too, the *Wiimote* fits in as naturally as your own arm, and the moves are similar to the ones you would use in reality. We don't wonder why this is the most popular game in *Wii Sports* worldwide.

Golf and *Boxing* are the game's disappointments. *Golf* has some pretty challenging holes, but the *Wiimote* detection doesn't work as seamlessly as the rest of the games, and isn't as immersive. *Boxing* requires you to hook up the *Nunchuck* for your other hand, and while the idea of boxing with the *Wiimote* in one hand and the *Nunchuck* in the other sounds excellent, the execution is quite badly flawed. For one, we couldn't really throw punches the way we wanted to, and there were even instances where the wrong fist would shoot out.

When you get bored of the games, there's always the *Training Room*, which gives you three levels of challenges for each game. These challenges are grossly underplayed in all the hype, but can be the best part about *Wii Sports*—imagine facing off with a friend to see how many strikes you can get in a row, and you'll see the potential in this.

In the end, *Wii Sports* makes for ideal party or family fun—especially *Bowling*—even though *Golf* and *Boxing* aren't what they could be.



Budget-friendly

The *Wii* is the cheapest console available today—we don't have the price for India, but it should be a bit more than the \$250 (Rs 11,250) that it retails for in the US. On the grey market, you can get one for as much as Rs 20,000—that's just Rs 3,000 less than a legal *Xbox 360 Premium*! We'd recommend conning a visiting relative into bringing you one, or waiting for the Indian launch. Titles cost around \$50 (Rs 2,250), which will quite likely become Rs 2,500 here—perhaps even Rs 3,000.

However, you don't need an HDTV to enjoy the *Wii*—a standard TV should do just fine. If you do have an HDTV, you'll have to shell out for the component cables as well.

Endgame

What do you look for in games? Would you rather see cutting-edge technology in action or enjoy a new concept? Do you want to be blown away by visuals and sound, or do you just want to have fun? Everyone

has their own philosophy on the ideal gaming experience, and most are quite hard-headed in that respect. But we dodge the subject: which console wins?

We'd compare the *Xbox 360* and the *PS3* on an equal footing for now—the games that have released thus far bring nothing to the table that propel the *PS3* into its own class. Unless we see a title that exploits the *PS3* in new and unimaginable ways, it can be compared to the *360* with no bias, and the latter takes the podium in that case. The *360*'s head start has given developers time to create games that showcase the *360*'s capabilities marvellously, and the number of titles that are releasing for it is just obscene. Unless Sony can catch up to those numbers, the *PS3* will always lag behind.

We don't dispute the *PS3*'s technological superiority, but games that can truly exploit the Cell will take some time, and should make the *PS3* the flavour of the season a year or two down the line—just not now.

And then there's the *Wii*. Just as we're bored with the same old keyboard-and-mouse for gaming on the PC, we're bored with the two-analogue-stick-four-button console controller. Where the *Xbox 360* and *PS3* redefine games, the *Wii* redefines gaming itself. Scoff at the ridiculous idea of getting up and sweating it out all you want, but there's no disputing how much fun it is. We're just hoping that third-party developers put their minds to the task and build better control dynamics.

Today's winner is the *Wii*. It's terribly addictive, and this is one addiction that will actually help you lose a bit of flab. It breaks away from the old to bring you something so radical and fun it'll leave you gasping for more. If, however, you're not like us and prefer beautiful and more complex games without having to get off your hindquarters, the *Xbox 360* is for you. It's cheaper than the *PS3*, has more titles to choose from, enjoys a healthy, throbbing community online, and even makes some games look better. There's also an embarrassment of accessories, and there's rumour that one of these will bring SIXAXIS-like capabilities to the *360* as well.

The *PS3* loses today, but its time will come. There's a lot of technology to be exploited there, and someone will do so soon enough. Until then, keep your *Wii* strap firmly fastened and stand clear of furniture and wayward family members. ■

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